

SPOILER-FREE PREVIEW

A family story under pressure.

Read an opening scene and one genuine exhibit from the expanded narrative edition. This preview contains no solution or hidden identity disclosure.

Inside the complete game: a sustained character story, an archive of inspectable records, working pages, progressive hints, an evidence-cited solution, and an expanded aftermath.

Play alone or investigate together. Every required clue is in the supplied papers. Print in grayscale or use the PDF bookmarks and catalog. No host or outside research is needed.

Player file: 29 pages. Preview pages are selected excerpts; their archive and story labels match the full edition.

THE STORY CONTINUES

The house waiting

Before the opening brief

The house had been locked for six days, but people still spoke as though one of them already owned the silence inside it.

Lawrence stood nearest Harcourt's desk. He referred to the place as ours, then corrected himself to the family property. Celia noticed the correction because she had spent a lifetime hearing the first phrase and being expected to understand that it did not quite include her.

"There is no need for everyone to be kept waiting," Lawrence said.

Harcourt arranged the petitions in the order received. "Then we should begin with the settlement."

"We know what our grandfather intended."

"We have what he wrote."

Peter Vale smiled at that. Celia saw it and wondered how long his pleasure in careful wording would last if the words troubled his own claim.

She had brought a petition too. Putting her name on it had felt more exposed than she expected. She did not pretend Lawrence's place in the family could be wished away. She wanted her own place recorded correctly, and she wanted the rules read before confidence hardened into possession.

"You might at least trust me to see you properly provided for," Lawrence told her.

"I am asking you to let the papers be read."

He looked hurt. She knew that hurt could be sincere and still make it harder for her to insist. Since Edward's death, people had been particularly ready to offer advice in the shape of decisions already taken for her.

Peter laid his hand on his petition. "There is an elder branch."

Harcourt did not move the keys toward him. "Then we will follow it."

Celia looked through the window at the house. Somewhere in its everyday arrangements were people who had to turn up for work regardless of which claimant won. A settlement might transfer property at an exact instant. The people depending on that property would have to live through everything that followed.

She drew her chair close enough to read. The task was not to choose the most persuasive person in the room. It was to establish who belonged in the line, where that person stood, and who was alive when Julian died. Celia intended to listen even when the answer ceased to help her.

The Ashcombe Settlement

Certified operative extract, register AS/1880/14. Settlor: **Gideon Ashcombe**. Appointed first life holder: **Julian Ashcombe**. Interest: the house, grounds and settlement fund as one indivisible estate.

R1 / What passes, and when

The house, grounds and settlement fund called the Ashcombe Estate pass together to one person at the death of Julian Ashcombe, the first life holder appointed by this settlement. Determine the successor at that instant, not at the later date of this inquiry. Julian has no power to appoint a substitute.

R2 / Who may succeed

Consider the descendants of Gideon Ashcombe through the parent-child relationships established in the certified birth and family records. Gideon himself and the outgoing holder are not candidates. A spouse or step-parent gains no descent relationship merely through marriage or a household description. No condition of sex, surname, occupation, wealth or marriage applies.

R3 / The order of the branches

Begin with Gideon's eldest child. Consider that child before their children. Then work through that child's descendants in the same way, taking each sibling in birth order and completing that sibling's branch before proceeding to the next. Only after the whole elder branch has been considered may the next child of Gideon, and that child's descendants, be considered.

R4 / Death and representation

A person must be alive at the succession instant to receive the estate. Bypass a person who died before that instant, but continue through their descendants in the place that person's branch already holds. Being closer in generations to Gideon does not move a person ahead of an elder branch.

Clauses R5-R8 continue on the next page. The appointment of Julian as first life holder does not establish branch priority for the succession after his death.